

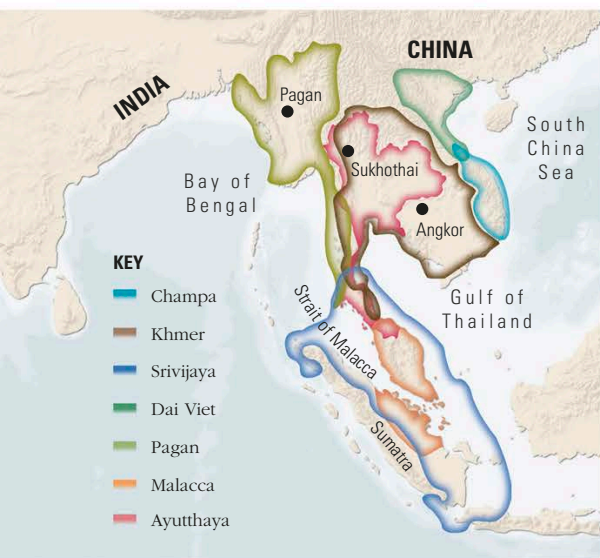
Kingdoms of Southeast Asia

Southeast Asia lies at one of the world's great crossroads, in the middle of a sea-based trade route linking India and China. From the 7th century onward, wealthy kingdoms rose across the region. The culture and politics of these kingdoms were influenced by their powerful neighbors, and, later, by contact with the Islamic world.

The kingdoms that thrived in present-day Cambodia, Myanmar (Burma), and Thailand were land-based and drew their wealth from rice farming. Other kingdoms, such as Champa in modern-day Vietnam and the Srivijaya Empire of Sumatra (in modern-day Indonesia) grew rich on sea trade. These kingdoms adopted Hinduism and Buddhism from India. Both religions spread rapidly and influenced all parts of life. The rulers of the powerful Khmer Empire in present-day Cambodia, for example, believed they were god-kings related

to Hindu deities. They built grand cities influenced by the cultures and kingdoms of India. Other kingdoms such as Dai Viet (in modern-day Vietnam) were dominated by China.

In around 1400, the Malacca Sultanate—the first Islamic sultanate in Southeast Asia—was founded in Malaysia. However, its wealth as a trading hub soon attracted the interest of European powers. Malacca was conquered by the Portuguese in 1511, beginning a new era of European colonization of Southeast Asia.



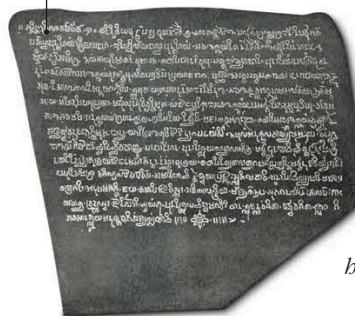
MAJOR KINGDOMS

The kingdoms of Southeast Asia rose and fell over time. This map shows the furthest extent of each empire at its peak.

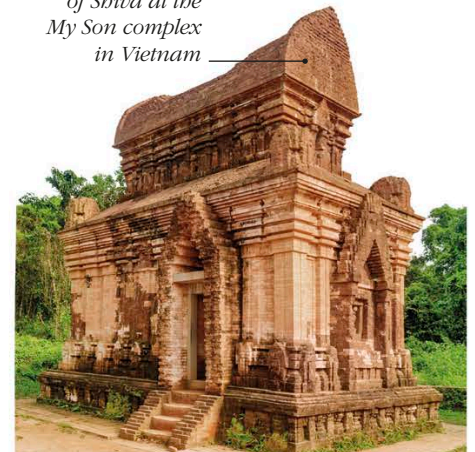
CHAMPA ►

On the southern coast of Vietnam, the Champa Kingdom lasted from the 2nd century CE to the 17th century but was at its height in the 9th and 10th centuries. The Cham people built temples to the Hindu deity Shiva with distinctive red brick towers. They were often at war with their Khmer and Dai Viet neighbors.

Dating to 684 CE, this inscription praises the establishment of a park by the Srivijaya king Sri Jayanasa.



Red-brick temple of Shiva at the My Son complex in Vietnam



SRIVIJAYA EMPIRE

The Buddhist Srivijaya Kingdom rose around 650 CE in present-day Sumatra and extended its rule to include the Malay Peninsula and parts of Java and Borneo. After its fall in the 13th century, it was largely forgotten until modern times when historians began piecing together its history with the help of inscriptions such as this one.